MAHATMA GANDHI UNIVERSITY, KOTTAYAM

MGU-UGP (Honours)/ MGU-BBA (Honours)/ MGU-BCA (Honours)

REGULAR EXAMINATION October 2026 ,Fifth SEMESTER ,Discipline Specific Elective (DSE) - MG5DSEHIS302 - INTRODUCTION TOMUSEUMS AND MUSEOLOGY

(2024 ADMISSION ONWARDS)

Duration: 2 hours **Maximum Marks: 70**

Part A

Short Answer QuestionsAnswer any 10 questionsEach question carries 2 marks

1. How would you explain the transition from private collections to publicmuseums?Private collections of rulers, aristocrats and scholars gradually became public museums through the Enlightenment, political revolutions and educational reforms. Collections were transferred to public institutions, systematically classified and opened to wider audiences. This transition changed their purpose from displaying wealth and prestige to promoting public education, research and heritage preservation.

2. Remedial Preservation Remedial preservation involves direct action on museum objects to arrest deterioration and stabilise their condition. Unlike preventive preservation, which controls environmental risks, it addresses existing damage. Measures include treating insect infestations, stabilising corroding metals and consolidating fragile materials. Such interventions require trained professionals, appropriate materials, careful documentation and minimal alteration.

3. Explain the importance of proper staff organisation in a museum. Proper staff organisation ensures efficient museum functioning through clear responsibilities, coordination and accountability. It assigns duties in collection management, conservation, research, education, exhibition and security according to professional expertise. Effective organisation prevents duplication, supports communication, improves visitor services and safeguards collections, helping the museum fulfil its educational and cultural responsibilities.

4. A museum wants to acquire an archaeological object. Why should itcheck the relevant laws first?A museum must check relevant laws before acquiring an archaeological object to establish legal ownership, provenance and compliance with excavation, export and import regulations. This prevents acquiring stolen or illegally excavated antiquities, discourages illicit trafficking, protects archaeological heritage and ensures ethical collecting, safeguarding the museum against legal disputes and penalties.

5. What is a specialised museum? A specialised museum focuses on a particular subject, discipline, community or category of objects rather than maintaining diverse collections. It collects, preserves, researches and interprets materials within its chosen field. Examples include archaeological, art, maritime, science and textile museums. Such museums provide focused knowledge and support specialised research and education.

6. Why is bequest a collection method? Bequest is a museum collection method because it transfers ownership of objects through a person’s will after their death. It enables museums to acquire historically, artistically or scientifically significant materials, often without purchase costs. Museums accept bequests after assessing their relevance, legal ownership, associated conditions and requirements for future care.

7. Security measures of museums ?Museum security measures protect collections, staff and visitors against theft, vandalism, fire and other hazards. Essential measures include trained guards, CCTV surveillance, alarm systems, controlled access, secure showcases and regular inspections. Fire detection, emergency exits, disaster preparedness, accurate inventories and staff training strengthen protection and ensure prompt responses to emergencies.

8. Explain the importance of the Act in protecting archaeological heritage. ?The Act provides legal protection for archaeological heritage by regulating activities affecting monuments, sites and antiquities. It helps prevent unauthorised excavation, destruction, encroachment and illegal removal of cultural objects. By establishing responsibilities, permissions and penalties, it supports conservation, safeguards historical evidence and preserves archaeological resources for research and future generations.

9. Identify the international organization that developed the Code of Ethicsfor Museums.? The **International Council of Museums (ICOM)** developed the **ICOM Code of Ethics for Museums**.

10. Explain the importance of gallery lighting. ?Gallery lighting enables visitors to see exhibits clearly, appreciate details and understand displays. It directs attention, creates atmosphere and supports comfortable movement through galleries. Appropriate lighting also protects sensitive objects by limiting harmful ultraviolet radiation, excessive illumination and heat. Balanced lighting reduces glare, improves accessibility and strengthens the overall experience.

11. Mention two amenities that can improve visitor convenience in amuseum. **Clean, accessible toilets**, including facilities for persons with disabilities. And **Seating and rest areas** within galleries and visitor spaces.

12. What is the importance of compensation under the Treasure-trove Act? Compensation under the Indian Treasure-trove Act, 1878, protects the interests of persons entitled to treasure when the government acquires it. Payment comprises the material value plus twenty per cent. This provision encourages reporting discoveries, discourages concealment and supports public acquisition of valuable finds for preservation, study and display in museums

[2x10 = 20]

Part B

Short Essay QuestionsAnswer any 6 questionsEach question carries 5 marks

13. Analyse the major differences between traditional museology and NewMuseology.? **Traditional museology** centres on **objects, collections and institutional authority**, emphasising acquisition, classification, conservation, research and display. Experts generally determine interpretation, while visitors mainly receive information. Museums often present established historical narratives within dedicated buildings. **New Museology** shifts emphasis towards **people, communities and social relevance**. It promotes participation, shared authority, inclusive interpretation and recognition of diverse identities. Collections are understood through their social contexts, including power, inequality and colonialism. Ecomuseums and community museums illustrate its broader approach to heritage. Thus, the major differences concern **object versus community orientation, expert versus shared authority, and preservation versus wider social engagement**, while retaining conservation.

14. Analyse the problems that may arise when museum documentation isincomplete.Incomplete museum documentation creates **uncertainty about an object's identity, provenance, ownership and significance**. Missing acquisition records can cause **legal disputes and ethical concerns**, especially regarding stolen or illicitly traded antiquities. Inadequate location records increase the risk of **misplacement, theft and loss**, while missing condition reports hinder conservation planning and damage assessment. Researchers may draw incorrect conclusions, and exhibitions may communicate misleading interpretations. Poor documentation also obstructs loans, insurance claims, audits and repatriation requests. Consequently, incomplete records weaken **collection management, institutional accountability and public trust**, reducing the museum's ability to preserve objects, support research and communicate reliable knowledge to future generations.

15. Explain the importance of budgeting and financial records in museums. **Budgeting and financial records** are essential for responsible museum management. Budgeting estimates income and expenditure, establishes priorities and allocates resources for **collections, conservation, exhibitions, staffing, security and visitor services**. It helps museums control costs, anticipate shortages and plan future development. Financial records document receipts, payments, grants and purchases, providing evidence of how funds are used. Accurate records support **auditing, legal compliance and accountability**, while helping prevent fraud and financial mismanagement. They also enable comparison between planned and actual expenditure. Together, budgeting and financial documentation strengthen **transparency, donor confidence and financial sustainability**, enabling museums to fulfil their educational and cultural responsibilities.

16. Explain why the legal definition of antiquity is important in controlling themovement of cultural objects? The **legal definition of antiquity** establishes which cultural objects fall under statutory protection, using criteria such as **age, historical significance and object category**. It provides a basis for regulating their **sale, transfer, import and export**. Clear definitions help authorities identify protected objects, require appropriate documentation and permissions, and distinguish lawful transactions from illicit trafficking. They also guide museums, collectors and dealers in checking provenance and ownership before acquisition. Without clear definitions, ambiguity can enable illegal movement and weaken enforcement. Thus, legal definitions support **consistent enforcement, accountability and heritage protection**, while facilitating the lawful movement of cultural objects for legitimate purposes.

17. Compare the institutional objectives and collection profiles of the IndianMuseum, Kolkata and the National Museum, New Delhi? The **Indian Museum, Kolkata**, established in **1814**, follows a **multipurpose approach**, preserving and interpreting both cultural and natural heritage. Its collections encompass **archaeology, art, anthropology, zoology, geology and botany**, supporting scientific study and public education. Indian Museum Kolkata The **National Museum, New Delhi**, established in **1949**, primarily presents **India's cultural heritage and historical development**. Its collections include **Harappan antiquities, sculptures, paintings, manuscripts, coins, textiles, decorative arts and arms**. Both institutions promote conservation, research and education. Their principal distinction lies in collection scope: the Indian Museum combines **natural history and human culture**, while the National Museum concentrates on **art, archaeology and the diversity of Indian civilisation**.

18. Analyse how the geographical and subject limits of a collection policyhelp a museum maintain a focused collection? **Geographical and subject limits** define the scope of a museum's collection policy. Geographical limits specify the regions represented, while subject limits identify relevant themes, disciplines or object categories. Together, they guide

acquisition decisions, ensuring that objects support the museum's mission. They prevent indiscriminate collecting, unnecessary duplication and the acceptance of unsuitable donations. A focused collection allows limited **funds, storage and professional expertise** to be used effectively. These boundaries also strengthen research, coherent exhibitions and meaningful interpretation. Periodic review allows justified changes while maintaining institutional purpose. Thus, clearly defined limits promote **collection relevance, responsible growth and effective management** over the long term.

19. Analyse visitor behaviour and identify factors that influence visitorsatisfaction in museums? **Visitor behaviour** includes movement through galleries, time spent viewing exhibits, reading labels, using interactive displays and interacting with companions. Visitors explore selectively according to their interests, prior knowledge, age and purpose. **Visitor satisfaction** depends on engaging collections, clear interpretation, comfortable layouts, appropriate lighting and accessible facilities. Helpful staff, cleanliness, seating, toilets and effective signage improve the experience. Overcrowding, fatigue, confusing displays and technical failures can reduce satisfaction. Inclusive interpretation and opportunities for participation encourage involvement. Studying behaviour through **observation, surveys and feedback** helps museums improve services, meet diverse expectations and create enjoyable, meaningful learning experiences that encourage visitors to return.

20. Explain how documentation supports the enforcement of the Antiquitiesand Art Treasures Act? **Documentation** supports enforcement of the **Antiquities and Art Treasures Act, 1972**, by establishing an object's identity, ownership and history. Photographs, descriptions, measurements and identifying marks help authorities recognise antiquities and distinguish them from replicas. **Registration records, provenance details and transaction documents** assist in verifying possession, tracing transfers and investigating suspected illegal dealings. Accurate inventories help detect missing objects, while export documentation assists authorities in examining compliance with restrictions. Such records provide **evidence for investigations, recovery and legal proceedings**. However, documentation alone does not establish lawful ownership; its accuracy and authenticity must be verified alongside the relevant legal requirements and circumstances.

21. Assess the significance of specialised museums in preserving specificaspects of Kerala's cultural and natural heritage.**Specialised museums** preserve selected aspects of Kerala's heritage through focused collection, conservation, research and interpretation. Museums devoted to **folklore, maritime traditions, archaeology, traditional crafts and biodiversity** safeguard objects, knowledge and specimens that broader institutions may overlook. They document local skills, community histories and environmental diversity, supporting education and specialised research. By involving practitioners and communities, they strengthen **cultural continuity and regional identity**. Natural history collections also provide evidence for understanding ecological change. However, their effectiveness depends on adequate funding, professional care and inclusive interpretation. Their significance lies in preserving **distinctive heritage within its wider social, historical and environmental contexts meaningfully**.

22. What is meant by a museum numbering system? A **museum numbering system** assigns a **unique identification number** to each object or accession entering a collection. This number links the object with its documentation, including provenance, acquisition details, location and condition. Applied using appropriate conservation methods, it supports **identification, tracking, inventory control and retrieval**, preventing confusion, duplication and loss.

[5x6 = 30]

Part C

Essay QuestionsAnswer any 2 questionsEach question carries 10 marks

23. Trace the origin and historical evolution of the term museum anddiscuss its changing meaning? The term **museum** derives from the Greek **mouseion**, meaning a place dedicated to the **Muses**, the goddesses of arts and learning. In antiquity, it referred to a centre of intellectual activity rather than a modern exhibition institution. The **Mouseion of Alexandria** exemplified this association with scholarship and research. During the **Renaissance**, the term became associated with collections of antiquities, artworks and natural specimens assembled by rulers and scholars. **Cabinets of curiosities** reflected interests in collecting, classification and discovery. During the **eighteenth and nineteenth centuries**, public museums expanded, transforming private collections into institutions serving **education, research and national identity**. In the twentieth century, conservation, professional management and public interpretation became increasingly important. **New Museology** subsequently emphasised communities, participation and social responsibility. Today, the museum is understood as an institution serving society through **heritage preservation, accessibility, inclusion and learning**, reflecting a shift from exclusive scholarly spaces towards public engagement and shared cultural understanding.

24. Describe the main causes of deterioration of non-biological museumobjects and explain the importance of preventive care? **Non-biological museum objects**, including metals, stone, ceramics and glass, deteriorate through **physical, chemical and environmental processes**. Excessive or fluctuating **relative humidity** encourages metal corrosion, salt crystallisation and instability in certain glasses. Temperature changes can cause expansion, contraction and cracking, particularly in composite objects. **Air pollutants, dust and soluble salts** promote surface damage, staining and chemical reactions. Light can fade pigments and painted decoration, while heat may damage associated materials. **Improper handling, vibration, impact and unsuitable storage** cause breakage, abrasion and deformation. Earlier repairs using incompatible materials may introduce further deterioration. **Preventive care** reduces these risks before damage occurs through environmental monitoring, suitable storage, protective enclosures, careful handling, regular inspection and emergency planning. Stable conditions and appropriate supports help preserve structural integrity and surface details. Preventive care is important because it **minimises irreversible damage, reduces the need for remedial treatment, lowers long-term costs and preserves the evidential and cultural value of collections**.

25. Explain the relationship between curatorial work, research andexhibition planning? **Curatorial work, research and exhibition planning** are interconnected museum functions that transform collections into meaningful public knowledge. **Curatorial work** involves selecting, documenting, interpreting and caring for objects, establishing the foundation for their use. **Research** investigates their provenance, chronology, materials, functions and cultural significance, while identifying gaps and questioning earlier interpretations. These findings guide **exhibition planning**, including the central theme, object selection, narrative sequence, labels and supporting media. Curators collaborate with conservators, educators, designers and communities to ensure that displays are accurate, accessible and sensitive to cultural contexts. Conservation assessments determine whether objects can safely be exhibited and under what conditions. Exhibition development may generate new research questions, while visitor feedback can reveal weaknesses in interpretation. Thus, their relationship is **continuous and reciprocal**: curatorial practice safeguards and organises evidence, research develops understanding, and exhibitions communicate that

understanding. Together, they support **responsible interpretation, public education and the museum's wider social and scholarly purposes**.

26. Describe the main elements included in the legal definition of anarchaeological site.Give a general introduction about acts and their importance then write about act of 1958. Under **Section 2(d) of the Ancient Monuments and Archaeological Sites and Remains Act, 1958**, an **"archaeological site and remains"** is an area containing, or reasonably believed to contain, ruins or relics of historical or archaeological importance. The definition includes several essential elements. First, it concerns a **geographical area**, rather than only an individual object or standing structure. Second, the area must contain archaeological evidence, or there must be **reasonable grounds for believing that such evidence exists**, allowing recognition before complete excavation. Third, the ruins or relics must possess **historical or archaeological importance** and have existed for **at least one hundred years**. Fourth, the definition includes **adjoining land needed for fencing, covering or otherwise preserving the area**. Finally, it encompasses **means of access and convenient inspection**. These elements recognise that archaeological heritage includes remains, their surrounding protective space and necessary access. However, classification under this definition does not automatically confer protected status.

[10x2 = 20